

Week 6 Pregame: vs cacheouts

Maple Tree Dashboard pregame. The doubleheader that puts the standings math to the test.

Week 6 is the doubleheader that puts the standings math to the test. Cacheouts walks in at 5-3 — a deceptively pedestrian record for a team that has been outscored by one total run on the season. They are exactly the kind of close-game opportunist Maple Tree has not been this year. Tonight is the night to find out which one of those teams is fooling itself, and the answer to that question lives at Boncosky Blue.

Game Setup

- 8:30 PM (Game 1, away) — Boncosky Blue
- 9:30 PM (Game 2, home) — Boncosky Blue
- Opponent: cacheouts (5-3, third in Blue Division on tiebreak)
- First meeting of the season — no head-to-head data on file

Tonight's Lineup

A 12-deep order tonight, with Slomka not on the card and the heart of the lineup unchanged from last week. 🔥 / ❄️ indicate last-5-game form vs season baseline.

1. **JJ** ❄️ — 1.480 OPS, .600 OBP, 13 runs already this spring. Career leadoff numbers in their normal place; last-5 has dipped to 1.329, but that is “cold” only relative to himself.
2. **Glove** 🔥 — 1.755 OPS, team-leading 19 RBI. Just crossed 100 career RBI last week. Two walks away from his 10th career walk if cacheouts decides not to throw him strikes.
3. **Tristan** ❄️ — 2.490 OPS, .680 AVG, 9 home runs in 29 PA. The “cold” stretch is a 2.255 OPS over the last five — still better than every other hitter in the league.
4. **Tim** 🔥 — 1.693 OPS, three home runs, riding a recent hot stretch. One PA from 100 career and two RBI from 50.
5. **Kives** 🔥 — 1.500 OPS after a three-HR Week 5. The five-hole has been earning its spot.
6. **Joel** 🔥 — 1.704 OPS in 19 PA. Two home runs from 5 career.
7. **Porter** 🔥 — 1.135 OPS, still hunting his first home run of the spring. One HR from his 10th career HR, one triple from his 10th career triple. He is sitting on a milestone Wednesday.
8. **Walsh** 🔥 — .913 OPS, also still searching for the first long ball. One RBI from 25 career, two HRs from 5 career — he and Porter are on identical milestone runways.
9. **Corey** 🔥 — 1.136 OPS, one walk away from his 10th career walk.
10. **Duff** — .982 OPS, steady form, one at bat from 200 career.
11. **Jason** — .933 OPS, steady, four RBI from 25 career and four runs from 50.

12. Joey — .686 OPS, in line for the 12-hole until the bat decides it would like to be somewhere else.

Seven of the twelve hitters are flagged hot heading in, the heart of the order is producing, and even the two “cold” labels are JJ and Tristan playing slightly below absurd. Eight of the twelve carry a 1.000+ OPS through eight games. The data from the analytics dive is unambiguous: a long inning at the bottom of the order matters more than a home run at the top. The team that gets the 12-hole back to the leadoff spot one extra time wins.

Opponent Snapshot: cacheouts (5-3)

Cacheouts has been the best example in the division of *winning close games when the math says you shouldn't*. Their season run differential is **negative one** — 122 runs scored, 123 runs allowed — and yet they are 5-3. Pythagorean expectation would put them somewhere around 4-4. They are running roughly one full win ahead of their underlying numbers, which is the exact opposite of what Maple Tree has been doing all season (and historically — five seasons of running *under* Pythagorean).

Looking at their box scores tells the story. **Five of cacheouts's eight games have been decided by two runs or fewer.** They beat No Dice 16-15 in Week 2. They beat Wasted Talent 26-24 in Week 3. They beat Wasted Potential 9-7 in Week 4. They lost to Bullseyes 24-23 last Wednesday and won the nightcap 14-13. This is a team that has trained itself to win the last inning of a tight game. That is the part of the sport Maple Tree has been mailing back unopened.

Through Common Opponents

Both teams have already played Bullseyes, Wasted Talent, and Wasted Potential. Six games each, same three defenses, same arithmetic:

	Maple Tree	cacheouts
Record	2-4	4-2
Runs scored	87	99
Runs allowed	104	89
Run differential	-17	+10
Per game scored	14.5	16.5
Per game allowed	17.3	14.8

The gap is real and it lives on both sides of the ball. Through the same three opponents, cacheouts has scored two more per game than Maple Tree and allowed two-and-a-half fewer. **The total per-game gap is about 4.5 runs.** Closing that gap is the entire game tonight.

The one place Maple Tree has the cacheouts archetype beaten: **offensive ceiling.** Cacheouts has scored 18 or more once all season (the 18-2 vs Wasted Potential blowout). Maple Tree has scored 16+ four times in eight games and crossed 23 twice. When this lineup is right, it produces louder than

cacheouts has produced. The question has never been whether the bats can show up. The question is whether the rest can.

What The Data Says To Do Tonight

Score 15. Maple Tree has scored 15+ in four of eight games this season; over five seasons, this franchise wins 72 percent of games where it clears 15 runs. Hit that number and history says you win.

Extend innings. Wins average 41.5 PAs per game. Losses average 33.2. Every extra trip through the order is worth roughly 2-3 runs of expected production. Foul off pitches. Take the borderline ones. Make cacheouts throw their fourth and fifth at-bat per hitter, not their third.

Contact over power. Hits correlate $r=+0.93$ with runs scored. Home runs correlate $r=+0.58$. The team that strings four singles together wins more games than the team that hits one solo HR. Tristan does not need to put one over the fence tonight. He needs Glove and JJ to be on base when he does.

The defense needs ONE clean inning per game. Cacheouts is a one-run-game specialist. The way you flip a close-game pattern is by playing the inning that turns a 13-13 game into a 13-9 lead. That is the math.

Watch List

Rank shown is where each hitter would land in franchise history if the milestone clears tonight:

Tristan — 3 TB from **300 career TB** (1st ever)

Tim — 1 PA from **100 career PA** (11th); 2 RBI from **50 career RBI** (6th)

Duff — 1 AB from **200 career AB** (4th)

Porter — 1 HR from **10 career HR** (6th); 1 triple from **10 career 3B** (4th)

Walsh — 1 RBI from **25 career RBI** (11th); 2 HR from **5 career HR** (7th)

Joel — 2 HR from **5 career HR** (7th)

Glove — 2 BB from **10 career walks** (5th)

Corey — 1 BB from **10 career walks** (5th)

Longer reaches: JJ needs 3 HR for 15 career (4th), Jason needs 2 BB for 25 career (2nd ever).

The Stakes

Maple Tree is 2-6. Cacheouts is 5-3. A doubleheader sweep tonight pulls those records to 4-6 and 5-5 — a one-game gap, with five weeks to go, and a real path back into the middle of the standings. A split keeps the gap at three. A 0-2 night opens the door to fourth and fifth place getting further away.

No Dice at 7-1 is functionally out of reach. That is the math. But every team between Maple Tree and No Dice is reachable on the schedule. The path to a winning second half starts by beating the team that has been winning *its* close games. Cacheouts has been getting away with a -1 run differential and

a 5-3 record because the variance has been on their side. Variance does not stay on one side forever. Maple Tree is owed a few of those bounces by every Pythagorean estimate this franchise has ever produced.

The bats are loud. The lineup is loud. The data says the wins are sitting there waiting to be collected. The team that has been losing the close ones gets a chance to start winning them tonight.

Two and oh, or this writeup is going to read very differently in a week. Let's go.